I wanted to create these hangings and banners and the entire work (*Three Storey House*), really, for actual grassroots movements. It's at the exhibition stage right now but, in an ideal world, they should be in public squares, maybe in pandals or riding...on the backs of trucks."

Throughout her career, Dube has been deeply interested in the idea of the sacred. Why do we worship the entities that we do? How do massively popular belief systems maintain and expand their hold on the public imagination? Her engagement with this theme has manifested in several interesting ways, like the usage of ceramic 'votive' eyes (the kind used to make statues of Hindu deities) in her works. The installation 'Strike' (2014) used these eyes in the context of warfare and large-scale conflict.

"This has been an idea that has stayed with me for much of my career," recalls Dube. "To take the tools and the icons of religiosity and apply them in secular contexts. In every society, the idea of religion is tied up with self-betterment... smarter, wiser, kinder. I am not a religious person, so the question for me is, how can I reach those same objectives? The goddess eyes, for example, speak to that question."

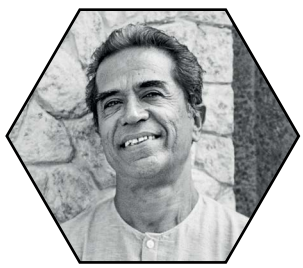
The ground floor segment of *Three Storey House* requires a degree of immersion from the visitor. It's a little unsettling by design and the storytelling is directly informed by George Orwell's *Animal Farm* and the key elements of the Dadaist movement (surrealism, humour, the uncanny/absurd). As Dube writes in the introductory text for the exhibition, this ground floor is "an 'Animal Farm', a 'Dada' place—with carnivorous leopards and snake-charmers cheered on by foot soldiers, while alienated individuals drunk on an unmindful 'me' culture climb on each other's back to create a mountain of aspiration (...)." While the text lays out the theoretical underpinnings of the work, one particular section of this 'ground floor' works in eye-catching fashion. A group of plastic-and-industrial material 'hands' start clapping the moment you get close to them (a motion detector set-up). And it's not shallow clapping but a loud and unnerving thunderclap applause that seems to bounce off the walls in reverberatory glee.

Always interested in **THE IDEA OF THE SACRED**, it has manifested in interesting ways in Dube's work, like the use of 'votive' eyes

"Orwell becomes an excuse for me to talk about the here and the now," says Dube. "You can see governments the world over adopting a more authoritarian stance. The applauding hands are triggered when you approach them because for a certain kind of leader, automatic applause is very important."

The narrative device of moving across a high-rise building—in the literal as well as sociological sense—is not unique. J.G. Ballard did it 50 years ago, in the 1975 novel *High-Rise*. But Dube truly makes this framework her own here, with every segment having something different to say. With its keen eye for allegory and its thematic nimbleness, *Three Storey House* offers an immersive experience. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha



The exhibition highlights Haku Shah's engagement with craft traditions and ecological symbolism through the synthesis of *mati* (earth), *ghat* (vessel) and *shakti* (feminine energy)

from different time periods; it has to be a conversation around the larger art history of the region," says Gudka, who is a South Asian art specialist. Mahendru is the founder of FAQ Art, a boutique art advisory firm that has worked with leading galleries, museums, private collectors and corporations.

The gallery represents 'The Estate of Haku Shah', and its inaugural exhibition, *Ya Ghat Bheetar/Rediscovering Form*, showcases a selection of his works, curated by Jesal Thacker. It deep-dives into Shah's seven-decade-long artistic practice, highlighting his engagement with craft traditions and ecological symbolism through the triadic synthesis of *mati* (earth), *ghat* (vessel) and *shakti* (feminine energy). Shah was influenced by the rhythms of rural life, which shaped his artistic/academic pursuits. "Haku Shah is known as an ethnographer, but we wanted to highlight him as a painter. There's a correlation of the paintings with the form of the *ghat* and the correlation of the *ghat* with the woman. Because that has been the crux of Haku Shah's work–documenting the processes of potters and craftspeople and integrating the act of creating, archiving and collecting into his artistic vision," says Thacker.

The exhibition presents about a dozen of his paintings, alongside an archive of photographs of potters at work and the resulting terracotta pieces. "At Subcontinent, we're committed to bringing forth the vision and legacy of Haku Shah as a modernist artist-thinker and building a nuanced appreciation of his practice," says Mahendru. ■

'Ya Ghat Bheetar/Rediscovering Form' continues until April 30 at Subcontinent, Apeejay Chambers, Fort, Mumbai

–Prachi Joshi